

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

HINDUTVA'S NEW POSTER BOY

Hindu nationalism seems to have a new icon. Assam may traditionally not celebrate Navratri but its chief minister **Himanta Biswa Sarma** bombarded social media with saffron-clad pictures of him doing Basanti Puja on all nine days. He also has a Gita post every morning now. Nor has he abandoned Assamese sub-nationalism. Recently, he lectured Bihu organising committees on how they should teach new generations about the dance form and not just stage events. Sarma did find himself in a spot when Union home minister Amit Shah said Hindi will be made compulsory in the northeast. "He never said our students should learn Hindi instead of Assamese," Sarma said in defence. "He said they should know Hindi besides their mother tongue." Well played, sir.

Gajendra's Charge

Union Jal Shakti minister **Gajendra Singh Shekhawat** is leading the BJP's charge against the Ashok Gehlot government in Rajasthan. On April 8, he warned five IAS and IPS officers that they would be arrested if the BJP came to power for allegedly tapping his phone in 2020. He also accused the CM of wrongly claiming that PM Narendra Modi had given assurances twice in 2018 that the Eastern Rajasthan Canal project will be given national project status; the PM had only promised a sympathetic technical assessment. A bid at chief ministership, should BJP win in 2023?



YASIR IQBAL



BITTER FEUD

Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief **Raj Thackeray** could barely conceal his joy when his daughter-in-law Mitali had a son on April 6. Over the next three days, MNS officials ferried special gifts to all prominent politicians in Mumbai, across party lines. The attractively wrapped gift contained chocolates and a signed letter expressing Raj's gratitude to all for sharing his happy moment. The gift-bearers, though, bypassed Matoshree, home of cousin Uddhav, also the state's chief minister. Some family feuds die hard.



WEAK WICKET

Gujarat chief minister **Bhupendra Patel** had hoped to please BJP boss J.P. Nadda when he chose the 130,000-seater Narendra Modi cricket stadium in Ahmedabad to launch a health festival for Divyang on April 7, initiated by Special Olympics Bharat, an NGO headed by Nadda's wife Mallika, along with the Gujarat government. The growing friendship between Mallika and his wife Hetal is a bonus. Patel also managed to persuade half a dozen of his cabinet colleagues and some two dozen BJP MLAs to attend. Sadly for the CM, only about a thousand stayed on, and this included the cultural performers. Bang ending in a whimper?

Entry, or Exit?



In July 2018, Lalu Prasad's elder son **Tej Pratap Yadav** got himself photographed with a placard that read 'No Entry, Nitish Chacha', obviously a note to Bihar CM Nitish Kumar that a rapprochement with the RJD was nigh impossible. Now, on April 10, Tej Pratap tweeted another placard, this one reading 'Entry Nitish Chacha'. Was Tej Pratap letting Nitish know that the RJD was ready to embrace him again? A day later, though, Nitish's JD(U) responded by poaching the son of Bihar RJD president Jagdanand Singh. Guess it's back to 'no entry' now.

–Kaushik Deka with Kiran D. Tare, Rohit Parihar and Amitabh Srivastava